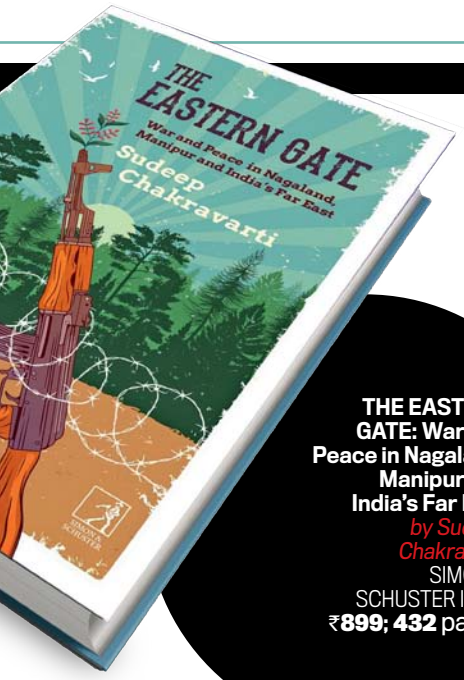


THE EASTERN GATE: War and Peace in Nagaland, Manipur and India's Far East
by Sudeep Chakravarti
SIMON & SCHUSTER INDIA
₹899; 432 pages

in concluding the peace talks with the group, which started in 1997. After almost 25 years of talks, there's still no solution in sight that is acceptable to all.

This book is primarily a detailed study of the long-running peace process that has tried to bring closure to the conflict in Nagaland, India's longest-running insurgency. It is part-journalism, part-history, with its focus—as the book's subtitle, 'War and Peace in Nagaland, Manipur and India's Far East', suggests—on the two states that are at the centre of the Naga issue. Chakravarti has been to most key places and met many of the top people involved with this issue. This includes the cast of characters usual in such places and matters—militants, spies, police and army officers, top bureaucrats, representatives of powerful civil society organisations and student bodies—and the person, who in many ways, is at the centre of it all, NSCN(I-M) chief Thuingaleng Muivah.

While there are several books on the Naga insurgency, they mainly fall into three categories: academic works, fiction and autobiography. None of them, to my knowledge, is a popular history on the details of the currently ongoing Naga peace process. Chakravarti's work plugs that gap. The passing engagement with other areas, such as Meghalaya, is largely extraneous to the main narrative and could probably have been left out without loss. That apart, *The Eastern Gate* is an excellent read, and a very useful one for people interested in the inner workings of the individuals, organisations and factors—including widespread corruption and the lucrative drug trade—that determine the fortunes of internal war and peace in Nagaland, Manipur and India's far east. ■

–Samrat Choudhury

The ex-deputy chief of the NSCN(I-M) army, Ramkathing Varah, is sitting with a Walther PPK in his hands...



The first person he interviewed was a cheerful caregiver who had nursed his terminally ill mother. She was Matua, a sect among the Namasudra community that had crossed the border from Bangladesh. The account of her struggle, told with candour and without bitterness, hinted at larger undercurrents—the long history of Partition, violence, migration, dispossession.

Unmaking communities in deltaic Bengal was also climate change, with the shifting terrain starting to play spoilsport. Poor peasants were set adrift by the periodic cyclones, floods and homes going underwater; they clung to *chars*, relocated to uninhabited land, made peace with the mangroves. New stories about the locality presented themselves to the author whenever he travelled to a remote school. Sometimes it was corporate greed, at other times, of the instrumentalities of state policy. One small campus was forced shut for ideological reasons—Maoists were against donations from foreign sources. The struggle was overwhelming.

The foul-mouthed boatman Nakul Sardar with deep knowledge of river systems; Savitri Munda, who had fallen foul of her village and escaped punishment as a witch; Sabram Banara, who told the author matter-of-factly that the Kolhos had roots in Harappa, are some of the heart-wrenching and moving portraits in this book. But there are poignant stories about teachers on the ground—Kanaicharan who had the tough job of allaying students' disappointment on days eggs ran short in the state-sponsored midday meal; Ananda, who had made it his habit to look out for children who came to school without breakfast.

PARIMAL BHATTACHARYA'S deep empathy is leavened with a luminous sensibility drawn from literary fiction

This book is more than a hard-hitting report on how the marginalised live in places where the *bhadralok* fear to tread. The author's deep empathy is leavened with a luminous sensibility drawn from literary fiction, reminiscent of the concerned and investigative travel writing by past masters in Bengali and English—Abdul Jabbar, Subhash Mukhopadhyay, V.S. Naipaul and Bruce Chatwin. ■

–Partho Datta